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A QUARTET OF CHALLENGES

THE TRIALS THAT INDIA FACES IN 2022 REQUIRE AT THE HELM MODI THE STATESMAN RATHER THAN THE POLITICIAN

The start of 2022 finds Prime Minister Narendra Modi facing a quartet of challenges that will test his leadership skills and his governance to the extreme: tackling the third wave of Covid, leading his party to victory in the upcoming five assembly polls, reviving the country's flailing economy and dealing with an aggressive China. As he hunkers down for the fight, the prime minister must feel like the Indian juggler that the 19th century English essayist William Hazlitt described in an article: "To catch four balls in succession in less than a second of time, and deliver them back so as to return with seeming consciousness to the hand again, to make them revolve round him at certain intervals, like the planets in their spheres, to do what appears an impossibility... a single error of a hair's breadth, of the smallest conceivable portion of time, could be fatal."

Each of the four challenges that Modi confronts are intrinsically linked, requiring the dexterity, coordination, reflexes, spatial awareness, strategic thinking and concentration of a juggler to tackle them. Take the rapid spread of the Omicron variant of Covid-19. It struck just when India was chuffed by the progress of its massive vaccination drive and had seemingly put the nightmare of the second wave in 2021 behind it. Some experts term Omicron the 'vaccine of vaccines'—a milder, yet vastly more contagious affliction that could make it an ideal instrument for global herd immunity. But it would be a folly to be complacent as the sheer caseload could overwhelm the health infrastructure. Taking cognisance of the fresh threat, Modi has rolled out vaccination for the 74 million young Indians aged between 15 and 18—plus, the fully vaccinated population above age 65 but with co-morbidities would be eligible for a booster dose too. The Modi government must now ensure that the states take measures to slow down infection rates and are well-equipped with adequate beds, drugs and oxygen for treatment. Meanwhile, several potential vaccines for even younger children need to be put on the fast track to cover most of the country's population.

Handling Omicron will determine how well the prime minister is able to juggle the other three balls. In politics, it's a no brainer that Uttar Pradesh is the prize. For Modi and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), winning the state with a convincing majority is key to building up the momentum for a third term and his ability to boldly govern India in the latter half of his second term. Modi's

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**